



Three to tango: Australia's Michal Burian, who won silver three years ago, got a bronze in Paris, while Sri Lankan Dulan Kodithuwakku went from bronze in Tokyo to silver in Paris. Sumit's place at the top did not change.

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after, Sumit threw what appeared to be around the 67m mark but intentionally fouled his effort. Much like Neeraj, he knows when he hasn't reached the distance his lofty standards demand.

"I just wanted to keep pushing my limits constantly. But it wasn't happening, and I was getting frustrated. The throw was among my lower ones, so I fouled. That throw too would have gotten me to the podium by itself, but I wasn't happy with it," he explained.

Sumit is a tall, big-built athlete, which makes weight control crucial to his technique and flexibility. The nagging back injury pushed the team physio, Vipin, to put Sumit on a strict diet that involved sacrificing sweets, something he grudgingly endures leading up to major events.

This time, it was even more important as losing weight would reduce the strain on his spine. Sumit makes the block with the artificial limb, which makes things even harder.

"My landing leg is the one with the artificial limb, and it's difficult to balance on it sometimes because only the heel connects with the ground. It's hard to balance the full body on two nails. After doing all the work to set up the throw, it all comes down to the blocking leg. In the final here, too, I was losing balance, so the throw was not as long as I wanted it to be," he added.

With the injury on his mind, Sumit needed to keep things as simple as possible. The advice he got from Neeraj Chopra before his campaign stressed the same.

"I didn't speak to him [Neeraj] personally. My manager, Dinesh, spoke to Neeraj's team, and he passed on a message to me. He said that the atmosphere was great. 'Don't try anything new. Your experience will be enough,'" Sumit said.

"My strategy was to secure the gold medal first. So I didn't do my warm-up throws either. I just did basic warm-ups. I had been training after taking painkillers, so I was a bit cautious at the start and careful not to do anything that might aggravate my back. In the last couple of throws, once I knew my gold was safe, I tried chasing down the world record (his own mark of 73.29m)."

"I had it in me. I was throwing better in training here than I did at the Hangzhou Asian Games where I got that world record."

But "gandi" (bad) technique, as Sumit sheepishly calls it, came in the way, potentially triggered by the fast Mondo track laid in the Stade de France for the Olympics and Paralympics.

"I could feel my leg skidding when blocking and throwing. We're not used to a track with such speed. I think my control was less than where it should have been. When I watched videos of my throws, I could see myself veering to the left a lot, which is not ideal. Mera technique bohot ganda tha. What I want to do is